

POU33201 — Mid-term essay
30% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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The short version

Weight	30% of the module mark
Length	2,000 words, 10% either way (excluding bibliography) — outside that range costs up to 5 marks
Due	Sunday 1 November 2026, 23:59
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Assignment Submission Form as page 1

Essay Topics

Choose **one**. Each asks you to build an argument using the academic literature — not to summarise it.

Topic 1: The Dictator's Toolkit

An autocrat can stay in power by **co-opting** rivals or by **repressing** them. Drawing on the literature on authoritarian survival, when and why do dictators rely on one strategy over the other? Illustrate your argument with at least one contemporary case.

Topic 2: Why Institutions?

Dictatorships routinely hold elections, run parliaments, and tolerate ruling parties — institutions that appear democratic but operate under authoritarian conditions. **Why?** Evaluate competing explanations (co-optation, credible power-sharing, information-gathering, signalling) and say which you find most persuasive, and why.

Topic 3: Durability vs. Fragility

Some autocracies endure for decades; others collapse with little warning. What does political science tell us makes an authoritarian regime durable — and what makes it fragile? Use the literature on breakdown, repression, and power-sharing, and apply it to **one** regime of your choice.

Topic 4: Build a Regime [TBD — pending Noah’s go/no-go, see `__drafting/DECISIONS-FOR-NOAH.md`]

A different kind of essay. Read the guidance below carefully before choosing it.

Pick a real country at a real moment in time — anywhere in the world, any point from 1900 to the near future — and write the counterfactual: **how would an authoritarian regime be built here, and how would it survive?**

The country may currently be a democracy (in which case you are describing an autocratisation episode) or an existing autocracy (in which case you are describing a transition from one kind of authoritarian rule to another). Your essay must answer:

1. **Where and when**, and what regime type you are moving *from* and *to*.
2. **How power is seized** — coup, self-coup, civil war, an authoritarian party, backsliding from within, or something else — and the pretext used.
3. **How the regime survives its first years** — the ruling coalition, the coercive apparatus, the basis of popular support, the international environment.
4. **How it survives decades** — which institutions, ideologies, economic structures and personalities do the work.
5. **Succession** — what happens when the leader dies or goes; this is where most regimes fail.
6. **How it might eventually end.**

This is not fiction writing, and it is not a morality tale. It’s an exercise in using the module’s toolkit — regime types, power-sharing, co-optation, repression, information control, coup-proofing — on a case concrete enough to resist hand-waving. Write as an analyst, from inside the regime’s own strategic logic; command of the theory is what earns marks.

Ground rules:

- **Your regime may not end in democratisation** — you are explaining how authoritarian rule is built and sustained.
- **Pick a real leader or real party** to head the regime wherever you can, rather than inventing someone.
- **Include one diagram** — a faction map, institutional schema, timeline, or party-system chart.
- **No “nothing went wrong” essays** (“what if the USSR never collapsed”) — clear it with me first if you want to attempt one.
- **It has to pass the smell test:** if you can’t explain the premise to a friend and have them nod, it won’t work on paper.

Two warnings, from experience with this assignment elsewhere:

- **The default answer is boring.** A Western European country, a far-right election win, capture the media and courts, stop there — it's the Hungarian playbook, but the interesting questions (how was the election won? what do the factions want?) get skipped.
- **The more alien regimes score better.** A closed party-state or military junta forces you to specify the whole apparatus — coercion, mobilisation, ideology, succession — and that's what shows command of the material.
- Counterfactual civil wars ("what if the losing side had won") work for the same reason.
- No credit for a regime you think I would approve of, or for democratising early. A neutral, analytic tone throughout is what impresses.

Requirements

- A **clear thesis** stated in the introduction.
- A body organised to support that argument with **evidence**.
- **Academic literature beyond the required readings** — analysis matters more than summary.
- A properly formatted **bibliography** (any consistent style).

Marked on argument, analysis, use of evidence, structure and writing.

Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine. No penalty and no advantage — this is not a virtue signal.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate counterarguments to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept or a hard passage — then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references: it invents them, and a fabricated citation is a fabricated citation regardless of origin. Sources must be ones you have actually read.

Submission-form category	This assessment
Writing assistance	Permitted only for text you have already drafted yourself — tightening, grammar, clarity, structural critique of your own draft. Generating a section from a prompt and then editing it is not “writing assistance”; that is the next row. If you use it, add a one-line note in an appendix saying which tool and what for.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted. No AI-generated text in the submitted essay, quoted and cited or otherwise.
Other use	Describe it on the form. If in doubt, ask me <i>before</i> the deadline; asking is never held against you.

The Assignment Submission Form must be page 1 of every written submission; a submission without a completed form is not accepted.

Late Submission

Penalties and extensions are set out in the [module outline](#): 5 marks per day, maximum 20; extensions through your College Tutor, never retrospectively.